



Puppy Foundations

Premium practice worksheet

PUPPY FOUNDATIONS • LESSON 04

Build comfort before you ask for duration.

Use this worksheet to make the crate or pen feel safe, predictable, and worth choosing instead of something your puppy only endures.

TRAINER NOTE

A good crate plan starts with comfort, not shut-the-door endurance.

START HERE

Dog: _____

Date: _____

Owner: _____

Best reward: _____

1 What success looks like

By the end of this lesson, the puppy can enter the crate or pen comfortably, settle with support, and spend short periods there without distress.

2 Practice plan

1

Create a positive entry

Toss treats in, feed meals nearby, and let the puppy go in voluntarily.

2

Add brief settle reps

Reward calm body language inside before your puppy starts asking to come out.

3

Introduce short closures

Close the door for a second or two, then open before stress builds.

4

Build short duration

Increase time only after your puppy can relax on several easy repetitions.



Puppy Foundations

Crate and Pen Comfort

3 Supplies and setup

Supplies needed

- ☐ Crate or pen sized appropriately
- ☐ Soft bedding if safe for the puppy
- ☐ Stuffed food toy or scatter feed option
- ☐ Light sheet or cover if it helps the puppy relax

Set up before you start

- ☐ Place the crate or pen in a quiet area with some family visibility.
- ☐ Decide on a release cue and keep it consistent.
- ☐ Start with very short, easy reps instead of long separations.

4 Crate and pen comfort tracker

Date	Setup	Dur.	Body language	What helped	Next step

5 5-day practice micro plan

Day 1

Set baseline

Find the easiest version and keep it calm.

Day 2

Repeat wins

Practice the same setup until it looks smooth.

Day 3

Add one tiny step

Add only one small challenge if yesterday

Day 4

Hold or simplify

If your puppy struggled, make today easier.

Day 5

Review notes

Choose the safest next step from your log.



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Crate and Pen Comfort

6 Common mistakes and quick fixes

Common mistakes

- Only using the crate when the puppy is upset.
- Jumping to long crate time too early.
- Letting release happen when the puppy is frantic.
- Ignoring whether the setup is too stimulating or too isolated.

If this happens, try this

- If your puppy barks right away, shorten the rep and reinforce earlier.
- If your puppy will not enter, feed at the doorway and work more gradually.
- If your puppy settles only with a chew, use that support and build from there.

7 Ready to progress?

- ☐ My puppy can enter the crate or pen willingly.
- ☐ I am ending reps before my puppy gets upset.
- ☐ I can read when my puppy is calm vs. simply tired or frozen.
- ☐ I have a realistic next duration to practice.

HOMEWORK

Complete two to four short comfort reps per day. Note what enrichment item helped the most and how long your puppy stayed relaxed.

8 Owner reflection

Biggest win: _____

What made it easier: _____

What should I repeat tomorrow: _____

QUESTIONS FOR YOUR FITDOG TRAINER

What should I make easier? _____

What should I practice again? _____

What is the next realistic step? _____